

4 Voices of the Voiceless

The Cold War and the Hmong
in Northern Thailand, 1965–82

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PRASIT LEEPREECHA

Mortars, paratroopers, and air support are being thrown into
the growing battle between the Red Meos and Government forces
in the North, a high-ranking police officer disclosed last night.

—“Red Meos Use Modern Weapons,” *Bangkok World*
(December 9, 1968)

Today, the Hmong, one of the largest highland ethnic minorities in Thailand, might be looked on as an object of exotic tourism, evoking images of peaceful and smiling Hmong women wearing colorful dresses. In Cold War Thailand, from the late 1960s to the early 1980s, however, they were considered the most dangerous enemy—the “Red Meo” (Hmong)—that supposedly posed a serious threat to national security.¹ During this period, Cold War competition heated up in the region. The Communist Party of Thailand (CPT), which had chosen the strategy of *Pa lom muang* (Jungles surrounding the cities), continued their guerrilla warfare in the jungles and borderlands of northern and northeastern Thailand, while the Thai government was determined to smash all communist forces throughout the country. Both sides approached Hmong villages in the region and provided weapons, and, as a result, tens of thousands of Hmong in the conflict areas joined each side. Many Hmong were killed by either government or communist forces. Much worse, Hmong communities were divided into two camps that confronted each other. Fear and antagonism were imposed on Hmong people who joined either side. Relatives and family members killed one another, leaving painful memories that haunt the Hmong people even several decades after the end of the Cold War. How did the Hmong people interact with the Cold War world? Why did they join both sides of the conflict, and what happened to them?

The Hmong are one of the ten highland ethnic groups—or so-called hill tribes—along with others such as the Karen, Akha, and Lisu.² They are a transnational ethnic group, scattered throughout southwestern China, northern Vietnam, northern Laos, northeast Burma, and northern Thailand. With the end of the Vietnam War and the establishment of the Lao People's Democratic Republic in 1975, many Hmong refugees evacuated from Laos to Thailand and eventually settled down in western countries, including the United States, Australia, France, and Canada. In 2016, it was estimated that there were 207,000 Hmong people in Thailand, and approximately 10 million throughout the world, mostly in China, Vietnam, Laos, and the aforementioned western countries.³

The Hmong have a long history. Legends maintain that they originally resided in central China, along the Yellow River, thousands of years ago, though they eventually escaped to mountainous areas in southwestern China due to the expansion of the Han Chinese. In the first half of the eighteenth century, during the Qing dynasty, some Hmong further moved from southwestern China to mountainous villages in northern Vietnam, Laos, and Thailand due to the increase in conflicts between the Hmong and Han Chinese settlers, as well as repressive economic and cultural reforms imposed by the Qing government.⁴ These Hmong ancestors eventually settled down in mountain villages of upper mainland Southeast Asia in the early nineteenth century, that is, long before the creation of the modern nation-states of Thailand and neighboring countries. According to Jean Mottin, a French Catholic priest, the Hmong started to migrate into the Tonkin area, which is at present northern Vietnam, in two waves from the 1800s to 1860s, and into the present northern Thailand areas from the 1830s to 1840s.⁵

In the colonial era, from the late nineteenth to the first half of the twentieth century, they became economically involved with two colonial powers, the British and French, the latter in Laos in particular, though the Hmong in Thailand were not subjugated by either. Around this time, the French colony and Thai government monopolized the opium trade, and the Hmong played a major role in cultivating and harvesting opium in order to sell it to both. That is why they preferred to live in high mountains with cold weather, areas that were suitable for opium cultivation, rather than lowland valleys.⁶

Then, in the 1940s, World War II broke out, though it did not affect Hmong people in Thailand in the way that it did the Hmong in French Laos.⁷ This was because, in Thailand, which was not colonized by any European powers, there were no prominent local or national Hmong leaders who took par-

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ticular sides in the war. Hmong who lived through this short period of war recalled that there was a "Japanese War," and that Japanese soldiers passed by their villages to the north. Some Hmong villagers remembered being forced to dig roads for them, while others were ordered to supply their horses to load Japanese soldiers' gear, though both of these lasted only for a few days. At the end of the war, when Japanese soldiers withdrew, some Hmong villagers bought their guns and bullets for hunting. In the early post-World War II era, anticolonial and independence movements spread like wildfire across many parts of Asia, but this did not impact the Hmong much either, largely because Thailand was not colonized by European powers or by the Japanese Empire.

Overall, prior to the escalation of the Vietnam War and Cold War politics, Hmong people in the mountainous areas of northern Thailand lived relatively quiet lives, isolated from the turbulence of global and national politics. In those days, they were mountain dwellers who were not controlled by the state government. Primarily due to low population density and the lack of state government regulation, Hmong people could move from mountain to mountain in order to find fertile lands for opium cultivation, remaining isolated in order to avoid disease contamination and keep themselves from being governed, as argued by James C. Scott.⁸ However, with the escalation of the Vietnam War and Cold War politics, which eventually had huge impacts on Hmong communities in the mountainous villages of northern Thailand, they began seriously being affected by and, even more importantly, actively taking advantage of the Cold War world.

There has been some literature concerning the roles of the Hmong in the Vietnam War and Cold War, but the Hmong in Thailand have mostly been described simply as "victims" of the conflicts, or as "terrorists" (or CPT soldiers) who posed a threat to national security.⁹ However, in this chapter, I would like to point out that the majority of the Hmong actually sided with the government and only one-third joined the communist side, many of whom joined the CPT to gain social justice and equal treatment. In short, Hmong experiences were much more diverse and ambivalent than is usually believed.

In a comparative dimension, as discussed by Masuda Hajimu, Native Americans and Chinese Americans made use of the Cold War to claim their civil rights and sovereignty and gain federal support.¹⁰ Instead of viewing the ethnic Hmong in northern Thailand simply as "victims" or "terrorists," we will see them similarly as active agents who took advantage of the Cold War to achieve social justice, equal treatment, and economic development.

As we will see below, basic infrastructure and development projects were brought to Hmong people on both sides, due to their prominent military contributions during the Cold War. As a result, the Hmong in Thailand, whose population was around just 50,000 in the early 1960s, transformed themselves from a marginalized and discriminated “hill tribe” into one of the most prominent minorities in Thailand, though, to be sure, they have remained to some extent marginalized and underrepresented in Thai society in general.¹¹

In addition to various primary and secondary sources, I have conducted and utilized oral history interviews with Hmong people on both sides of the conflict. An oral history approach is crucial for this research because the Hmong ethnic group did not have its own writing system until 1951, when the Romanized Popular Alphabet (RPA) system was introduced by missionaries who worked with the Hmong in Laos and Thailand.¹² While this has since become popular among the Hmong people, many older and non-Christian Hmong still cannot read and write. Thus, for the Hmong, oral transmission is the most important way to hand down stories from generation to generation.

Oral history can reveal Hmong villagers’ direct experiences and points of view, which have been often obscured under the dominance of official records and existing documents that have tended to represent stories and perspectives of the mainstream—that is, in this case, the Thai government’s—position. As Robert Perks and Alistair Thomson have explained, official narratives in written documents are more powerful and publicly accessible than narratives transmitted orally among villagers: “Through oral history interviews, working-class men and women, indigenous peoples or members of cultural minorities, amongst others, have inscribed their experiences on the historical record, and offered their own interpretations of history. More specifically, interviews have documented particular aspects of historical experience which tend to be missing from other sources.”¹³ Hence, conducting oral history can shed light on the experiences of people who have been hidden or misrepresented in mainstream narratives.

As stated above, under the influence of Cold War narratives, the Hmong people who sided with the CPT have been stereotyped as “terrorists” or “Red Meos,” despite the fact that the majority of Thai people did not know why they took arms against the government from the beginning. Even though they were often labeled negatively as “separatists,” what I have found is that they fought to protect themselves from being oppressed by state authorities. Furthermore, we know quite a lot about the Hmong who

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joined the CPT in the jungles, but, in reality, the majority of Hmong in Thailand sided with the state government as soldiers and village volunteers, though their stories have never been documented or publicized in mainstream Thai society. Below, we will see why the Hmong people decided to join the CPT or the government side, and what kinds of loss and gain they eventually experienced from fighting on both sides.

Southeast Asia and Thailand's Cold War

In Thailand, communist movements had their roots in the early 1930s. Following Ho Chi Minh from Vietnam, with the help of Vietnamese and Chinese immigrants in Thailand, the "Communist Party of Siam"—the predecessor of the CPT—was established in Bangkok in April 1930.¹⁴ In response, in 1933, the Thai government declared an anticommunist act, arresting many communist members and sympathizers and deporting them to their homelands.¹⁵ In the post-World War II period, such movements developed rapidly, mostly in urban areas, and thus the Thai government issued another anticommunist act in November 1952, banning the CPT and strictly controlling printing and other activities pertaining to communism.

Due to heavy suppression by the government, communist movements ceased operations in towns. Then, the CPT announced the strategy of "Jungles surrounding the cities"—*Pa lom muang*, in Thai—in 1958, emphasizing publicity campaigns toward the lower classes of people in both urban and rural areas who had been exploited and maltreated in Thai society. As a result, many villagers believed that they had hope for better lives, voluntarily joining the party and attending political and military trainings.¹⁶ The first deadly armed battle between villagers and police—often called the "First Gunfire Day," or *Wan Siang Puen Taek* in Thai—occurred at Nabua village in Nakorn Phanom Province in northeastern Thailand on August 7, 1965. It marked the first day in Thai history in which deadly armed fighting between the CPT and the Thai government broke out. Following this incident, the CPT declared a militant strategy of armed struggle against the government.¹⁷

Following this battle, armed clashes spread throughout the country, especially in northern and northeastern Thailand, where the CPT had its greatest influence.¹⁸ Meanwhile, on the opposite side, the Thai army set up the "Center for Subjugating Communists" for the purpose of getting rid of communists throughout the country.¹⁹ Yet, the government could not eliminate communist movements in Thailand; rather, those movements

intensified in the deep jungles of north and northeast Thailand, bordering with Laos, where they set up army bases and training centers, in areas that were inhabited by a number of ethnic groups, including the Hmong. One reason the CPT set up bases in these border areas was that they received significant support from China, Vietnam, and Laos, although later the Sino-Soviet conflict complicated this situation.

During the political turmoil in Thailand in the 1970s, not only farmers but also university students joined the CPT forces. This was particularly the case following the October 6, 1976, massacre at Thammasat University in Bangkok, when the lives of more than 2,000 university students were threatened, causing them to flee to northern Thailand's deep jungle area. This was because the CPT had established close relationships with the Hmong and other ethnic groups in mountain villages since the late 1960s. In this area, including Nan, Chiang Rai, Phayao, Petchabun, Phitsanuloke, and Loei provinces, the Hmong and other ethnic people became the CPT's core soldiers and civil supporters, accepting and taking care of newcomers from urban areas.²⁰ So, to begin with, why did the Hmong people decide to join CPT forces?

Hmong Fighting on the Communist Side

While only one-third of the Hmong in Thailand joined CPT forces, they played crucial roles in the CPT's armed fighting because of their high ability in jungle and guerrilla warfare, which was one reason that CPT leaders trusted Hmong soldiers and relied on them for protection. For the Thai government, on the other hand, the Hmong army—or "Red Meo army"—became an embodiment of fear. While Thai military officials generally did not fear any CPT forces if they were fighting in non-Hmong zones, the Hmong soldiers frightened them considerably and, in fact, caused much damage to Thai armies. News of the fighting was reported daily to the public; the headline of *Bangkok World* on February 13, 1968, for instance, stated, "Meo Blast Copter, Kill Six Soldiers, Chiengrai Northern Thailand," reporting that "an officer and five soldiers have been killed by Communist Meo tribesmen in remote village near the Laotian border."²¹

This is why images of "Hmong Communists" or "Red Meo soldiers" evolved into representative images of CPT forces that became widely known among the Thai public. In such imaginings, the Hmong people were even vilified as "separatists," secretly maneuvering to establish their own country. However, through detailed examination of the experiences of these Hmong soldiers, we can see that their fierce fighting derived from their op-

pression by the government, and that they joined the CPT forces not for the creation of their own country, but to defend and demand basic rights and dignity.

Although there has been some research on why many Hmong joined the CPT since the late 1960s, none has deeply investigated the direct experiences of those affected at the grass roots of conflict and warfare in mountainous villages. In the late 1980s, a prominent scholar in Hmong studies, Nicholas Tapp, attempted to link the Hmong uprising against the state government to the myth of the return of a legendary Hmong king, with an emphasis on the contemporary political context of the state government's habitual oppression. The problem with this argument, however, is that he did not carry out a firsthand survey among Hmong soldiers who had joined the CPT.²² Thus, based on my oral history interviews with such former Hmong soldiers, I would point out more practical and personal factors: that is, Hmong villagers' negative and often miserable experiences with government authorities.

The dominant exercise of power among state authorities who reached mountain peoples in the mid-1960s and the simultaneous propaganda of the CPT resulted in the Hmong retreating to the jungle in northern Thailand. For instance, Bua Haw Yang, a former key Hmong leader who joined the CPT forces and now lives in Maneepreak village, Nan Province, recalled his experience and motivation as follows. After the clash between the CPT and Thai government forces in neighboring Nasa and Pha Daeng villages in 1966, Thai soldiers came to his village as the government had supposedly received information about communist activities there. Two Hmong men in the village were arrested, interrogated, tortured, and taken to Nan city for further investigation. This caused other Hmong villagers to fear similar raids and leave for the jungle to hide. Meanwhile, a few Thai people, who later turned out to be communists who had been trained in China, showed up in the village. They pointed out that the only way to avoid such cruel acts by Thai soldiers was to get out from under their rule, and that the CPT and communist doctrine would offer an opportunity to achieve such justice and freedom.

According to Bua Haw Yang, these communists told villagers that the only way to react to such brutal domination was to take arms to fight state authorities. After a while, the situation got even worse. The Thai government learned about communist activity in this jungle area and sent Thai soldiers to subdue it. Due to general hatred of communism and a common misunderstanding of all Hmong people being "Red Meos," Thai soldiers burned all of

the Hmong villagers' houses in Pang Nong village in December 1967. Worse still, two nephews of a Chinese Hmong leader, who had been trained by the Thai Border Patrol Police and who worked on the government side, were killed by communists. Amid the confusion and chaos, Hmong villagers in seven neighboring villages dispersed; some joined CPT forces in the jungle, while others decided to move closer to the Thai government in the lowlands.

Government authorities' immoderate behaviors concerning local civilians were another main reason for ethnic Hmong to flee and join the CPT in the jungle. Such officers' attitudes were described in a common Hmong proverb as follows: "Facing tiger one will die, facing officer one will be deprived" (*ntsib tsov ces yuav tuag, ntsib nom ces yuav pluag*). For example, in the neighboring village of Kang Haw, just a few hours' walk from Manee-pruek, a young Hmong, La Yi Lee, who was recruited by Border Patrol Police for training at that time, recalls the following:

Around 1964, some government officers came to our village, though some were just traveling and passing by our village. Hmong villagers faced negative experiences with these officers. Whatever group of officers visited our village, they asked for taxes to be paid to the government. A leader of each group always claimed that they were the official representative of the government agency in charge of tax collection. Even eggs in chicken coops were taken by these authorities. They even shot pigs raised by villagers. Hmong villagers, thus, compared such behaviors to those of the wolf. Whenever villagers saw state officers showing up, they informed other neighbors, "Wolves are coming, hurry up to hide your valuable items!"²³

The government's forcible resettlement plan was another major cause for the Hmong people to join the CPT to protect their basic rights (see figure 4.1). In the Hmong village of Khao Kho, Petchabun Province, Va Long Lee, a former leader of CPT forces in the area, recalled the government's relocation program and government officials' arrogant attitudes:

At the beginning we lived in Phu Hin Rongkla, part of the Phu Lomlo and Phu Khithao, of Phitsanuloke Province. In 1964, we moved to Khao Kho Mountain in Phetchabun Province. Then, two years later, in 1966, we were compelled to move back to Phu Lomlo because the government was planning to set up Phu Lomlo to be a "Hill-Tribe Resettlement Site"—or *Nikhom Songkroh Chaokhao* in Thai. Villagers pleaded with the government for transportation, but government

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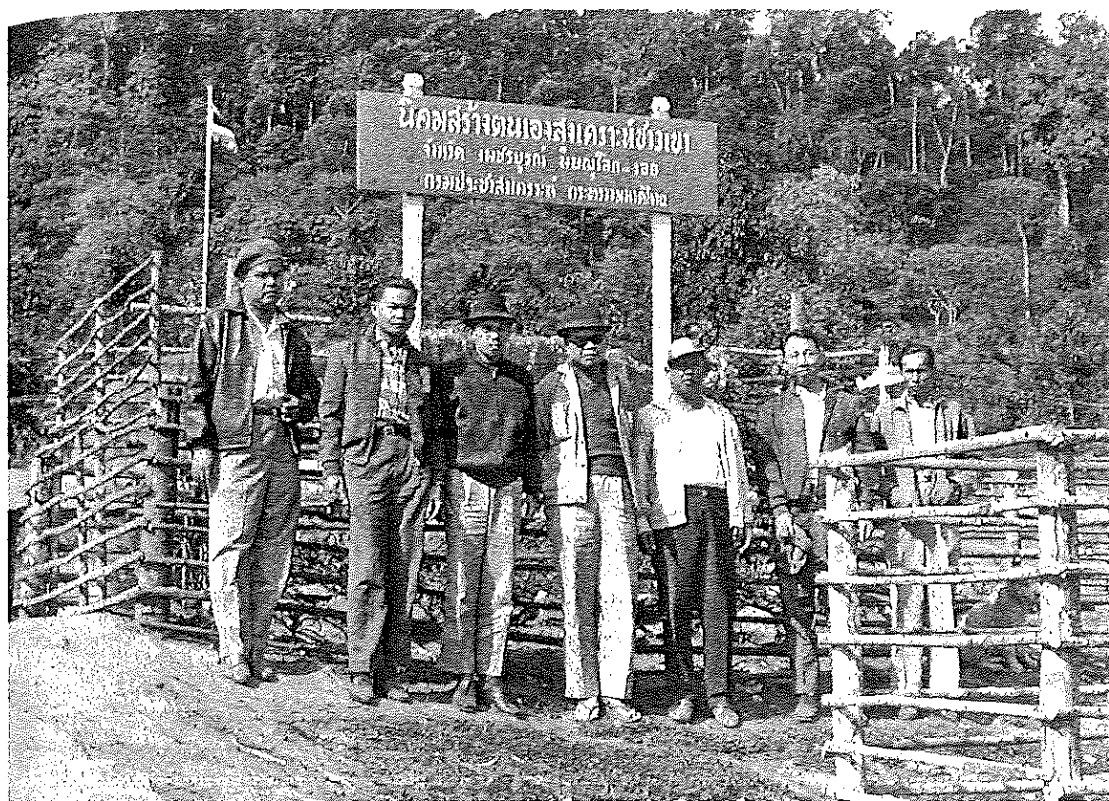


FIGURE 4.1 Hill-tribe resettlement site of Phu Lomlo in 1965.
Courtesy of the former Hill-Tribe Welfare Division.

officials refused. More pressures for resettlement were put on villagers; thus, fifty Hmong leaders traveled to Bangkok in order to appeal to high-ranking officials for help. In Bangkok, however, they were poisoned with dinner foods provided by government officials, though nobody died. They asked the officials of the Public Welfare Department to bring them back home. Then, soon after they arrived in their villages, all of them left for the jungles since no one trusted the government anymore. In this same year of 1966, all Hmong people in our village and other neighboring mountainous villages were forced to move out, leaving for the new settlement site in Phu Lomlo.²⁴

Va Long Lee continued to explain about his villagers' miserable experiences and his difficult decision to join the CPT forces:

Thai soldiers were sent to every Hmong village in that area. They even dared to shoot to intimidate villagers to join the resettlement program. After that, only small numbers of Hmong villagers agreed to join the government's resettlement project and moved to the

resettlement site. Most villagers decided to flee to the jungle since they were scared by soldiers' intimidating shooting. At that time, I was an assistant to our village headman. We, the four representatives of the villages, appealed to our villagers who were already hiding in the jungles to come out and surrender to the government's instructions for resettlement. By that time, many Hmong villagers didn't trust us and some even threatened to kill us because we had been discussing with the government. However, while negotiating with government officers, they [the officers] also suspected that we had told villagers to join the CPT in the jungle since by this time the communist movement had already been spreading in the Phu Hin Rongkla area, and some Hmong people had sought communist help. Eventually, in order to protect my life, I decided to join my people in the jungle in 1967.²⁵

Another Hmong villager, Nao Bee Lao, who lived in a nearby village on Khao Kho Mountain at that time, likewise recollected what happened. He also remembered the event in which fifty Hmong leaders went to and returned from Bangkok. According to him, after that event, a group of lowland Thai people came to his village and asked to buy pigs. After having a conversation, they asked the villagers if they had any problems. The villagers said to them that they were now being forced by the government to move out and resettle in Phu Lomlo. The villagers explained that they had asked the government for help with transportation but in vain, and that the villagers would have to move to the new resettlement site all by themselves.

Then, according to Nao Bee Lao, those visitors told the villagers that the government would give them only three months, either to resettle into the project site or to escape to the jungle. The visitors further offered the Hmong people training programs and weapons if they did not want to go to the resettlement site and wanted to protect themselves. By that time, the villagers realized that these visitors were CPT members. Then, according to Nao Bee Lao, quite a few Hmong, including himself, joined the CPT and came to receive training in communist thought in the forest for three months; nine months later, they actually received weapons that had been brought from China. In late 1968, these Hmong people dispersed into the jungle and joined the CPT to fight against the Thai government (see figure 4.2).

In this way, during the turbulent years of the late 1960s—particularly from late 1967 to early 1968—more and more young Hmong men and women escaped to the jungles to join the CPT, and many were sent to China for further training as the CPT had been developing close relationships with the

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FIGURE 4.2 Hmong soldiers of the CPT with a Thai student.
Courtesy of Comrade Chart Saelee.

Chinese Communist Party (CCP). One young Hmong who was recruited and trained in China was Nao Bee Lao, mentioned above. He said that he started paying attention to how to use both herbal and modern medicine after experiencing severe sickness due to malaria as well as chemical powder dropped on Hmong by government aircraft, circa 1968. Then, in 1975, he was sent to China to study medicine. He joined the CPT group and walked from Khao Kho to Phu Miang, Uttaradit Province, and then crossed the border into Laos. Under the leadership of Lao comrades, he walked further and eventually crossed the Laos-China border, arriving at Simao, the Chinese town at the border.

From Simao, they took an airplane to Kunming and connected to Wenshan County by helicopter. In Wenshan, Nao Bee Lao spent four years studying medicine, with a focus on surgery and anesthesiology. In addition to medicine, he studied political and military sciences. After completing all of the training programs, he was sent to several major cities in China on a number of inspection trips before eventually returning to work in Thailand in 1979. One year later, in 1980, the Thai government declared amnesty for

those who had joined the CPT in the jungle, which resulted in the return of students, farmers, and Hmong people to their families and communities, thus ending Thailand's Cold War. Therefore, he and other relatives decided to settle down in Khek Noi village, Phetchabun Province, where they have remained to the present day.²⁶

Former Hmong leaders on the communist side, such as Va Long Lee and Nao Bee Lao, had already begun sensing that their war would end sooner or later. Communist China had begun adopting a new line of reforms and open-door policies. New conflicts arose between China and Laos, which resulted in the cutting off of a supply route that had been used to bring many goods and weapons from China to northern Thailand. These Hmong leaders had been involved in various forums for discussion and political analysis at both local and regional levels, and thus they had been vaguely aware that it would be impossible to continue their fighting for long. Nevertheless, for rank-and-file Hmong soldiers and villagers who fought on the CPT side, the sudden end of the war was a bolt out of the blue. They were very upset when they were told by their leaders that the CPT leadership had made an announcement that soldiers should hand in their weapons and surrender to the Thai government. "They were angry that CPT leaders had betrayed the Hmong people by asking them to fight for fourteen years but eventually gave up in 1981. On that day, the CPT's Hmong soldiers shot toward the sky, shouting with anger," said Song Lo Lao.²⁷ Eventually, however, the Hmong who joined the CPT disarmed themselves, and most went back to the mountain villages where they had lived prior to fleeing to the jungle, while others agreed to join their relatives in the lowlands.

While their sense of loss was unmistakable, it is simplistic to view the Hmong who joined the CPT as mere "victims" whose lives were trifled with in the turbulent seas of the Cold War. Looking more closely, we can see that they experienced gains by taking advantage of this situation. First of all, they were able to use Cold War politics to protect themselves, rectify injustices, and improve their social status. Prior to the arrival of the communist movement in the mid-1960s, Hmong in northern Thailand, along with other highland ethnic groups, had been looked down upon, often being cheated, oppressed, and heavily taxed by local authorities. For example, when local officials visited Hmong villages, they usually identified themselves as *Pho Fa*, literally meaning "Lord of Sky" or "King from Above," regardless of what kinds of agencies they belonged to. They not only behaved in a high-handed manner in villages, but aggressively collected taxes in the forms of both money and opium. Worse still, villagers were

often cheated. Khu Vang Yang, a senior Hmong leader in Nan Province, recalled, "More than one team visited our village every year, especially following opium-harvesting season in January and February. Each team claimed that they were the real government representative to collect taxes."²⁸ Thus, Hmong villagers had been suffering cruel treatment and heavy taxes on farm fields, livestock, children, and even women's breasts, as well as lightbulbs even though no villages had electricity in those days, according to Moh Daeng, a Hmong leader in Chiang Rai Province.²⁹ For those villagers, the communist movement was a powerful weapon—or even a sort of savior—to fight oppression and to bring justice.

Second, the Hmong could use the communist movement as a vehicle to get opportunities for education and practical training. In fact, many young male and female Hmong were recruited and sent to study in China and Vietnam. For those people, including Nao Bee Lao, discussed above, as well as Moh Daeng and Phukong Laozee, two prominent medical and military leaders in Hmong communities in Chiang Rai Province, there was little hesitation to accept communists' offers to study in China, as the Thai government and society at large at that time did not offer such opportunities to the Hmong and other highland ethnic groups. They walked for months through northern Thailand to Laos, to Vietnam, and to China, where they met Hmong people from other areas. Such medical and political trainings were conducted in China, while military trainings were carried out in both Vietnam and China. After being trained for a few years, they were sent back to their own villages. In some cases, even their children's generation was sent to China in the late 1970s. For those who did not go to China or Vietnam, other kinds of opportunities were provided to take courses and learn military activities in the jungles of northern Thailand. It should be noted that Hmong women were trained for gender equality and played much larger roles in various activities than those who sided with the state government.

Third, the Hmong could use the Cold War world as a way to improve their social status and, eventually, gain more recognition among the Thai public. Due to their prominent roles in armed fighting in the jungles, "Hmong" came to be synonymous with CPT soldiers causing serious damage to the Thai military. Because of that, the Thai government and public came to detest Hmong communists, but at the same time such impressions caused a sort of respect among Thai soldiers and society. For instance, there were some people in Thailand who were not Hmong but fled to the jungle because of their negative experiences with government authorities. While staying in the jungle, these people came to understand why Hmong people had fled

to the jungle and taken arms to fight against the state government. They learned from the Hmong people while, in return, teaching and training them. Then, gradually, the Hmong's fame rose, which can be seen in a surge of publications in the twenty-first century. There have been many accounts, for example, of the lives of Hmong in the jungle, personal experiences of Thai comrades with the Hmong, and so forth.³⁰

Thus, by now, stories of the Hmong who fought on the side of CPT forces have become relatively well known. Yet, that is only one side of the coin, as the majority of Hmong villagers actually did not join the CPT. Much less known are the stories of Hmong who sided with the Thai government. How did they choose to join the Thai government side, and why?

Hmong Fighting on the Government Side

In the conflict zones, such as Chiang Rai, Phayao, Nan, Loei, Phitsanuloke, and Phetchabun provinces, some Hmong people who disapproved of communists joined the Thai government side, although many of them had had unpleasant experiences with local authorities. Looking back, their choices seemed to be personal and even coincidental, rather than ideological or pre-determined. Generally speaking, these Hmong tended to have close relationships with relatively nicer and more trustworthy local officials. Some had been recruited and trained by those authorities when they were younger. Khu Vang Yang, a senior clan leader in Nan Province, for example, recalled that Thai Border Patrol Police often visited his mountain village, Kang Haw, circa 1962, recruiting four young men from each village in the region and sending them to their training base in Chiang Mai Province. After being trained, these young men were sent back to their villages to teach and lead various development projects, and to gather information about communist movements.³¹

La Yi Lee was one such representative. He was recruited to join the "Hill Tribe Development Team" at the Thai Border Patrol Police Base in Chiang Mai Province in 1965. After being trained there for two and a half months, he and the other three were sent back to their village to teach villagers how to use modern medicines, how to cultivate and raise livestock, and how to identify and monitor communist activities. Their new roles, with their close relationships with Border Patrol Police, naturally caused tensions with those who had been sympathetic to the CPT or those who detested government authorities. Clashes among these opposing villagers eventually broke out in neighboring villages in 1967. Two of La Yi Lee's relatives in a nearby vil-

lage were murdered by CPT soldiers. Then, rumors spread, maintaining that La Yi Lee and the other three would sooner or later be killed by communists. By the end of 1967, they, along with their families, had decided to leave their village, moving to the safe zone in lowland areas, where American missionaries had set up a mission station and where some Hmong students had already been staying in a Christian hostel. Eventually, their relatives and other villagers decided to follow these four families, moving to the lowland and settling in the Paklang Resettlement Village in early January 1968.³² This was how Hmong people in Kang Haw and other villages “chos” their sides, while Hmong in many other villages dispersed into the deep jungle and joined the CPT.

By the same token, some Hmong leaders in Phetchabun Province had close relationships with local authorities and Christian missionaries who had been expelled from China and took the government’s side after coming to Thailand. Chertua Lee, a former village headman, recalled becoming Christian and choosing the government side. His father was also a village headman, and thus he was in a position to get to know local officials, soldiers, and American missionaries in the early 1950s. Then, in the mid-1950s, his family became one of the first pioneer families to convert to Christianity. After that, they came to have a closer relationship with the missionaries.

A turning point arrived in the mid-1960s when communist activities in the region become conspicuous. The family consulted with missionaries and, as advised, joined the Thai government side. Chertua Lee was already an assistant to the village headman by that time, and thus he led a few other families down to the lowlands, while many other families decided to flee to the jungle. Four years later, he even became one of the leading Hmong figures who promoted the creation of a new resettlement site at Khek Noi. To protect this new village from communist attacks, he devoted himself to training and setting up a vigilance group, *Thaharn Chao Khao Arsa Samak* (Hill Tribe Volunteer Soldiers for Village Protection) and *Chao Khao Chai-daen* (Hill Tribe Border Police Force). Similar vigilance groups were set up in neighboring Hmong resettlement villages in Nan and Phayao provinces. Some of the major resettlement sites included Paklang and Songkwae in Nan Province, Prachapakdee in Phayao Province, Khek Noi and Lao Lue in Phetchabun Province, and Chedi Koh in Tak Province.

In addition, as Thai authorities learned of the reputation of Hmong soldiers on the CPT side, the army and Border Patrol Police began training young Hmong men in the resettlement sites (see figure 4.3). Hmong soldiers became the majority of their volunteer forces, playing crucial roles in the



FIGURE 4.3 Young Hmong and Mien (Yao) Hill Tribe volunteer soldiers in Pratu Pha Training Camp, Lampang Province, 1971. Courtesy of Thawatchai Charuprapatsorn.

fighting. According to Chua Chai Yang, one of the pioneering Hmong volunteer soldiers, Hmong soldiers were no longer just guarding the village, but fighting side by side with Thai soldiers in mountain battlefields such as Khao Kho and Phu Hin Rong Kla, because they were accustomed to high mountain terrain.³³ "Skirmishes between Hmong soldiers on both sides occurred quite often. We had to fire at our enemies if we didn't know whether they were Hmong or not. If we saw and knew that they were Hmong, we just avoided firing," said Chua Chai Yang. Needless to say, quite a few Hmong volunteer soldiers were wounded and died in such battles. Many Hmong civilians who sided with the Thai government were also wounded and died because they stepped on land mines set up by communist soldiers.³⁴

Hmong volunteer soldiers' monthly payments were much lower than those of official Thai soldiers, but they earned moral support and respect from Thai army officials and the general public, as well as benefiting from various kinds of developmental projects in the resettlement sites created to help new residents. Land was provided for each family, and new crops and cultivation techniques were introduced. Basic infrastructure, such as dirt roads, reservoirs, wells, water pipe systems, and even schools, was provided. Furthermore, "Hill Tribe Public Welfare Centers" were set up in each resettlement site to provide food, shelter, and healthcare services for the Hmong and other highland refugees soon after they arrived. Family and individual registration surveys were conducted, and citizenship was granted to these Hmong people. In addition, youth gained a chance to go to school;



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some went to local village schools, while others were sent to towns for further study. Upon completion of certain levels of education, young Hmong and other ethnic people had opportunities to become public welfare workers, agricultural extension staff, local schoolteachers, soldiers, and members of the Border Patrol Police. Having grown up in such a village, the author of this chapter is, in a sense, one of the long-term products of the Thai government's development projects.

Ultimately, although the Cold War caused pain to the Hmong who decided to side with the government in the late 1960s, it also entailed opportunities for them to move down to lowland areas, where they shared in the benefits of various kinds of developmental projects. Hmong refugees, to be sure, faced many difficulties in adapting to lowland ways of life, and some had to struggle for survival. Yet, during half a century of living in lowland villages and towns, their offspring more radically changed their ways of life in comparison to the Hmong who sided with the CPT and were eventually exposed to modern life in the 1980s.

Conclusion

Prior to the 1960s, the Hmong people lived in remote and mountainous villages in northern Thailand. They rarely had contact with lowland Thai officials and villagers since there were no roads or transport vehicles. In the mid-1960s, with the escalation of the Vietnam War and with the dissemination of Cold War politics in Thailand, the Hmong first became a target of the communist movement due to their geographical position as well as their grievances with state authorities. By the late 1960s, government officials were being sent to Hmong villages in order to persuade villagers to side with the Thai government.

Such a dissemination of Cold War politics caused chaos for local Hmong people. Hmong leaders who had negative experiences with the state government tended to side with CPT forces, while those who maintained relatively more congenial relationships with local authorities tended to side with the government, thus opposing and fighting each other up until 1980. Because of such tensions among Hmong villagers, not only Hmong leaders but even close relatives were divided into two camps. Distrust among Hmong leaders and villagers on opposing sides caused the killings of many Hmong leaders and villagers on both sides. Many also lost their lives in battles against the government or CPT. Therefore, it is not surprising that, even four decades after the end of Thailand's Cold War, memories of the

conflict still haunt the Hmong people regardless of whether they sided with the CPT or the Thai government.

In the Hmong language, an occurrence of disease contamination is described as *ib phaum mob*, literally meaning a “wave of disease,” which spreads quickly and then disappears a while later. In this way, Hmong leaders who fought on both sides of Thailand’s Cold War often use this metaphor of a “wave of disease” for the Cold War. According to this view, the Cold War was a political and ideological conflict that occurred far away in the global context but devastatingly affected the Hmong people in national and local contexts. It was a sort of “disease” that made the Hmong excited to take up arms but that left them blamed and stereotyped as “Red Miao”—the most dangerous tribes to national security—in the eyes of the state government and the general public. What was wrong, in this view, was the Cold War itself, which came and went. Thus, Hmong leaders and villagers’ actions could be pardoned, making it possible for them to live together harmoniously. Indeed, the young Hmong people who grew up in the post-Cold War period have been harmoniously united, leaving memories of Cold War conflicts behind. Yet, in doing so, Hmong people’s agency during the Cold War era has been rather obscured, making them appear mere victims.

Based on oral history interviews with Hmong leaders and villagers, I have, rather, explored the ways in which the Hmong people interacted with the Cold War world. Instead of looking merely at its impact on them, I have taken the other way around and investigated how they took advantage of the Cold War. What we have seen is that, although the Cold War did have a devastating impact on the Hmong, it was more ambivalent and complicated for them than is usually believed. We have seen that they could take advantage of their situation. Whether belonging to the government or the CPT side, they could rectify injustice to some extent. On either side, they could find opportunities for education and development. More importantly, the Hmong—a small ethnic group in Thailand with a population of 50,000 prior to the 1960s—became one of the most prominent ethnic groups in Thailand, with a population of 207,000 as of 2016, and well known nationally and internationally. In a sense, it could be said that the Hmong were able to open doors for broader sociopolitical and economic opportunities thanks to the Cold War.

During the national election campaigns in May 2019, Phukong Laoyee, one of the most prominent former communist Hmong leaders, and his Hmong team shed new light on their battles during the Cold War. According to him, he began fighting for social justice at an early age by leaving to

join the CPT in the jungle for almost two decades. He emphasized that, although the Hmong people have attained a certain level of justice and recognition, new problems have emerged, such as cases of being toyed with in competition for natural resources, or of being scapegoated for drug smuggling. While his team did not gain any seats in the House of Representatives, his movement had a big impact. In fact, another Hmong politician, who is a son of former Hmong CPT soldiers in Tak Province and a member of the *Anakhod Mai* (New Future) party, did win in a national election and became a member of the House of Representatives. Moreover, not only these Hmong politicians, but younger Hmong generations in general, have been playing essential roles in local politics and civil movements. While the battleground has changed from the jungles to the legislative assembly, the Hmong's fight for justice and recognition has been continuing.

Notes

1. "Hmong" is the term that the Hmong people in Thailand use for themselves, while they consider "Meo" and "Miao" derogatory terms used by non-Hmong people. However, in China, the term "Miao" is a broader category that includes the Hmong and other groups, without any negative connotation.

2. Other hill tribes include the Karen, Akha, Lisu, Lahu, Yao, Khamu, H'tin, Lua, and Mlabri. Thai government officially categorized them as "hill tribes" from the late 1950s to the mid-2000s. Presently, these peoples prefer the term "Indigenous people" to refer to themselves.

3. Kong Nikhom Sang Ton Eng Lae Patthana Chaokhao [Division of Self-Help Settlement and Hill Tribe Development], *Thamniab chumchon bon phuenthisung, krobkrum phuenthi 20 changwat khong prathet Thai, prachampi 2559* [Directory of highland communities, in 20 provinces of Thailand in 2016] (Bangkok: Department of Social Development and Welfare, Ministry of Social Development and Human Security, 2016).

4. Robert D. Jenks, *Insurgency and Social Disorder in Guizhou: The "Miao" Rebellion 1854-1873* (Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press, 1994).

5. Jean Mottin, *History of the Hmong* (Bangkok: Odeon Store, 1980). Also, see Christian Culas and Jean Michaud, "A Contribution to the Study of Hmong (Miao) Migrations and History," in *Hmong/Miao in Asia*, eds. Nicholas Tapp, Jean Michaud, Christian Culas, and GarYia Lee (Chiang Mai: Silkworm Books, 2004), 61-96.

6. William R. Geddes, *Migrants of the Mountains: The Cultural Ecology of the Blue Miao of Thailand* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1976).

7. In Laos, the Hmong people were divided into two opposing camps, one on the French and the other on the Japanese side, fighting each other. Due to this background, a civil war occurred in Laos when the French left in 1953. See, for example, Keith Quincy, *Hmong: History of a People* (Cheney: Eastern Washington University Press, 1988); Mai Na M Lee, *Dream of the Hmong Kingdom: The Quest for*

Legitimation in French Indochina, 1850–1960 (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 2015); and Touxa Lyfoung, *Tub Npis Lisfoom tej lus tseg cia* [The remnant words of Touby Lyfoung] (St. Paul, MN: Touby Lyfoung Foundation, 1996).

8. James Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2009).

9. See, for instance, Jane Hamilton-Merritt, *Tragic Mountains: The Hmong, the Americans, and the Secret Wars for Laos, 1942–1992* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1993); Chia Youyee Vang, *Fly Until You Die: An Oral History of Hmong Pilots in the Vietnam War* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2019); and Prasit Leepreecha, “Heroes of the Plain of Jars: Hmong Monuments and Social Memory in Laos and America,” *Journal of Mekong Societies* 16, no. 3 (2020): 44–78.

10. Masuda Hajimu, “The Early Cold War: Studies of Cold War America in the Twenty-First Century,” in *A Companion to US Foreign Relations: Colonial Era to the Present*, ed. Christopher R. W. Dietrich (Hoboken, NJ: Wiley Blackwell, 2020), 2:632–51.

11. For the population in the early 1960s, see Oliver Gordon Young, *The Hill Tribes of Northern Thailand: A Socio-ethnological Report* (Bangkok: Thai-American Audiovisual Service, 1961). For the population in 2016, see *Thamniab chumchon bon phuenthisung*, 8.

12. Yves Bertrais, *How the Hmong R.P.A. Was Created and Had Spread from 1953 to 1991* (Guyana: OMI, 1991).

13. Robert Perks and Alistair Thomson, *The Oral History Reader* (New York: Routledge, 1998), ix.

14. Eiji Murashima, *Kamnoerd Phak Communist Sayam (Pho So 2473–2479)* [Birth of Communist Siam Party, 1930–36] (Bangkok: Matichon, 2012).

15. Suthachai Yimprasert, *Phaen ching chart thai: Wa doy rat lae kan totan rat samai chomphon Poh Phiboonsongkram khrang thi song (Pho So 2491–2500)* [On the state and the resistance to the state during the reign of Marshal Poh Phibunsongkram, the second time, 1948–57] (Bangkok: P. Press, 2007).

16. Ninlawadee Promphakping, Maniemai Thongyou, and Viyouth Chamruspanth, “The Extension of State Power and Negotiations of the Villagers in North-east Thailand,” *Southeast Asian Studies* 6, no. 3 (December 2017): 415–16.

17. Promphakping, Thongyou, and Chamruspanth, “Extension of State Power,” 415–16.

18. Thikarn Srinara, *Lang 6 Tula: Wadui Khwamkhatyaeng thang khwamkhid Rawang Khabuankarn Naksuksa Kap Phak Communist Haeng Prathetthai* [Post 6 October: On ideological conflict between students and Communist Party of Thailand] (Bangkok: 6 Tula Ramluek, 2009).

19. Saiyud Kerdphol, *Pho Kho Tho Hai Pai Nai?* [Where does the CPT disappear?] (Bangkok: Aksorn Samphan, 2011).

20. Klum Phoen Nan, *Tamnan Dao Phraophrat Thi Phuwae Phuphayak* [Bright star legend on Phuwae and Phuphayak] (Bangkok: Art Edge Graphic, 2009); Chanthana Fongthale, *Chak Doiyao Thuong Phuphaji: Buntuk Pravattisart Kandoenthang Khong Numsao Haeng Duantula* [From Doiyao to Phuphaji: Historical records on journey of Young People of October] (Bangkok: Praew Printing, 2013); Mai Lee, *Phayu Fon*

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Bon Phuphaji-Phachang [Rain storm on Phaji-Phachang mountains] (Pathumthani, Thailand: Rangsit University Press, 2016); and Thikarn, *Lang 6 Tula*.

21. *Bangkok World*, February 13, 1968.

22. Nicholas Tapp, *Sovereignty and Rebellion: The White Hmong of Northern Thailand* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1989). More recently, Ian G. Baird has studied the transnational, transcultural, and gender-relation-transforming experiences of the CPT Hmong people, but has not looked at how and why the Hmong got involved in Cold War politics. See Baird, "The Hmong and the Communist Party of Thailand: A Transnational, Transcultural and Gender-Relations-Transforming Experience," *TRaNS: Trans-Regional and -National Studies of South-east Asia* 9, no. 2 (2021): 167–84.

23. La Yi Lee, interview with the author, August 2007.

24. Va Long Lee, interview with the author, July 2019.

25. Va Long Lee, interview.

26. Nao Bee Lao, interview with the author, June 2019.

27. Song Lo Lao, interview with the author, August 2019.

28. Khu Vang Yang, interview with the author, July 2016.

29. Moh Daeng Lee, interview with the author, March 2015.

30. See for instance, Chanthana, *Chak Doiyao Thuong Phuphaji*; Khana Tham Ngan Anusorn Phuphayak Changwat Nan, *Tamnandao Praoprai Thi Phuwaie Phuphayak* [Brighten stars legend at Phuwaie Phuphayak] (Bangkok: Art Edge Graphics, 2006); Mueanfun, *Lang Mai Daodaeng* [Red star behind the microphone] (Bangkok: 6 Tula Ramluk, 2005); Mueanfun, *Su Samoraphum Naewna* [Heading for forefront battle field] (Bangkok: 6 Tula Ramluk, 2008); and Siriluk Chanthavong, *Khoun Su Phuphayak* [Claiming to Phuphayak] (Bangkok: Sukhaphap Jai, 2006).

31. Khu Vang Yang, interview.

32. Prasit Leepreecha et al., *50 Pee Paklang: Chak Yoddoi Su Phuennarp* [50 years Paklang: from mountain to lowland] (Nan, Thailand: Chomrom 50 Pee Paklang, 2018).

33. Chua Chai Yang, interview with the author, June 2008.

34. Chua Chai Yang, interview.